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The Creative Role of Doubt in Religion

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ABSTRACT: This essay contains four arguments in defense of the creative role of doubt in religion. Within a specified framework or context it is argued that: 1) creative doubt is a means of constructively acknowledging human finitude, 2) creative doubt can play a role in keeping one's fundamental beliefs alive and vital, 3) creative doubt, by continually challenging the full adequacy of religious symbols, serves as a check against the idolatrous worship of one's own religious language, and 4) the avoidance of doubt may reflect a relinquishing of freedom and a dehumanizing quest for certainty.

A college student approached his professor after class. With anguish he complained, "I don't know whether you know it or not, but this class is painful." "How's that?" the professor asked. "Well," the student continued, "you have convinced me that we ought to do what you are encouraging us to do, but when I do what you suggest, it's so painful."

What had this professor suggested? What had he encouraged his students to do, the doing of which created, in at least one student, pain? He had encouraged them to doubt creatively. That is, he had encouraged his students to challenge and evaluate the fundamental values—ethical, political, and religious—to which they were committed. At first glance, it may seem as if anyone who would sanction, much less encourage, such activity is an intellectual cynic determined to create psychological chaos. Before such a judgment is rendered, however, attention should be given to the nature of creative doubt and to the reasons that can be advanced in its defense. That is the purpose of this essay.

These arguments are intended, however, to be taken within a certain framework or context. The context can be made clear by contrasting the situations of two individuals, one historical and one fictional. The historical figure is Socrates. The fictional character is St. Emmanuel, the protagonist of Miguel de Unamuno's short work, "St. Emmanuel the Good, Martyr."

Concerning Socrates, recall the cardinal principle he defended at his trial, as that trial is recounted in Plato's *Apology*. The unexamined life, he argued, is not worth living. By this claim Socrates meant that to be a rational human being is to have a kind of creative doubt about one's fundamental value beliefs, a creative doubt that promotes, within reason, a continual reappraisal of such beliefs. This Socratic attitude is vividly illustrated in the dialogue *Euthyphro*.

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Socrates encounters the young Euthyphro on the porch of the courthouse early one morning. In response to Socrates' query about why he is there, Euthyphro replies that he is in the process of prosecuting his own father and adds that the act of bringing his father to account is itself an act of great piety. At that point Socrates commends Euthyphro for his courage and wisdom and for the piety that he claims. By the way, asks Socrates, what is piety anyway? And with that question Socrates opens the way for a lengthy conversation in which it is revealed that Euthyphro is quite confused about what genuine piety comes to, even though he is prosecuting his father precisely because he thinks to do so is an act of piety. In the process Euthyphro is challenged to rethink some of his most fundamental ideas. This dialogue and this incident are very revealing of the activity of Socrates. He viewed himself as a gadfly with a god-given task of stimulating men to think, to evaluate critically the fundamental principles in terms of which they were structuring their lives. There is an ethics of belief, Socrates would have argued. And one is morally justified in holding a belief only to the extent that it can be justified after critical assessment. Consequently, he not only sanctioned but openly stimulated creative doubt.

Consider, on the other hand, St. Emmanuel, Unamuno's creation. Emmanuel was parish priest of the small, rural village of Valverde de Lucerna. His story is told by his only two educated parishioners, Angela Carballino and her brother Lazarus. Angela describes Emmanuel: "How he did love his people! His life consisted in salvaging wrecked marriages, in forcing unruly sons to submit to their parents, or reconciling parents to their sons, and, above all, of consoling the embittered and the weary in spirit; meanwhile he helped everyone to die well."[1] "The priest's effect on people was such that . . . everyone confessed themselves to him without the need of a confessional."[2] "When it came to dying . . . most of the villagers refused to die unless they were holding on to Don Emmanuel's hand, as if to an anchor chain."[3]

Eventually Angela's brother Lazarus comes to understand that Emmanuel, upon whom the villagers depend so thoroughly, no longer believes certain religious doctrines that have provided for his parishioners such peace and happiness. When Lazarus encourages Emmanuel to proclaim the truth as he sees it, Emmanuel responds: "'The Truth? The truth, Lazarus, is perhaps something so unbearable, so terrible, something so deadly, that simple people could not live with it!'"[4] Committed to the proposition that the happiness of his parishioners is the ultimate value, Emmanuel argues that "'it's better for them to believe everything, even things that contradict one another, than to believe nothing. The idea that someone who believes too much ends by not believing in anything is a Protestant notion. Let us not protest! Protestation destroys contentment and peace.'"[5] The case he makes for his point of view is so persuasive that eventually even Angela and Lazarus judge him to be a saint among saints and a genuine martyr.

Here we have, then, an age-old conflict. Socrates versus Emmanuel. Truth versus happiness. And the reason it is an age-old conflict is precisely because the competing claims of the two values—truth and contentment—are both so compelling.

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When, in fact, the values of truth and happiness *are* in conflict, that is, when the truth is painful or when happiness is dependent upon refusing to pursue the truth, surely the value taking priority depends upon the nature of the situation. This opens the door for a possible resolution of the suggested conflict between Socrates and Emmanuel.

Socrates, one might argue with considerable plausibility, was addressing his "the unexamined life is not worth living" remarks to students, teachers (i.e., the traveling sophists), and the political leaders of Athens. Emmanuel, on the other hand, makes clear that he is concerned with the well-being of the simple, uneducated people of his rural village. And what one does, for example, in the classroom with students who have paid their money ostensibly to be stimulated to think and what one does in conversation with a ninety-five-year-old grandmother whose dogmatic and inconsistent religious views are her abiding source of joy and comfort are surely two different things. All of this is to say that the following arguments are in defense of stimulating creative doubt in certain contexts, while acknowledging that there are other settings in which such activity would be inappropriate.

Consider, then, four arguments in defense of creative doubt.

Acknowledging human limitations

First, creative doubt is a means of constructively acknowledging human limitations. The American pragmatist Charles Sanders Peirce addressed himself to this issue in terms of his doctrine of Fallibilism.[6] This view states simply that with regard to matters of fact human beings are fallible; they can never be absolutely certain that they are correct. "This," observes Peirce, "is my conclusion, after many years study of the logic of science."[7] The scientist recognizes his limitations and, at most, claims a greater or lesser degree of probability for his conclusions. The implication here is that science has made the progress it has precisely because of a methodology that acknowledges limitations and, therefore, encourages reevaluation of conclusions. Acknowledging the possibility that he might be mistaken, the scientist stands prepared to alter his beliefs in the light of new evidence. Should the philosopher or theologian, asks Peirce, be less sensitive to *his* fallibility, less prepared to alter *his* beliefs if reason and evidence warrant? No knowledge claim, concludes Peirce, is ever absolute but "always swims, as it were, in a continuum of uncertainty and indeterminacy."[8] Such an epistemological conclusion is an inevitable corollary of human fallibility.

In this context, consider the notion of faith. What has just been said concerning the possible fallibility of any given human belief is relevant to an understanding of faith. To be sure, belief and faith are not identical, but belief *is* involved in faith. Paul Tillich's analysis of faith as "the state of being ultimately concerned"[9] is widely held. It must be emphasized, however, that ultimate concern is always intentional: that is, if one is ultimately concerned, one is ultimately concerned *about* something. Faith, then, is wholly committing

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oneself to that which one *believes* to be of ultimate value. Tillich himself argues that "it must be stated as sharply and insistently as possible that in every act of faith there is cognitive affirmation."[10] But where there is cognitive affirmation, there is the possibility of error due to human limitations. And, again, Tillich has forcefully insisted that doubt is a part of the very structure of faith.[11]

Care must be taken, however, in what one attributes to Tillich. He distinguishes in *Dynamics of Faith* between methodological doubt (the kind of humility Peirce associates with the scientific method), skeptical doubt ("an attitude of actually rejecting any certainty"[12]), and existential doubt. It is the latter that Tillich explicitly claims is an essential dimension of faith. In fact, and despite his disclaimers, Tillich's actual discussion of the dynamics of faith suggests that methodological and skeptical doubt are also inherent in faith. For to the extent that faith involves cognitive affirmation, to that extent methodological and skeptical doubt also should be seen as part of the structure of faith. The very fact that faith can be misplaced, that is, that one can take as ultimate that which is not ultimate at all, is a reflection of the logical possibility that a person may be mistaken. Even if one refers to his ultimate concern as "God," humility insists upon the question: Does one's understanding of God correspond to reality? Creative doubt encourages this question. Dogmatism suppresses it.

In connection with this proposition that creative doubt is a means of acknowledging human finitude, a segment from Bronowski's film series "The Ascent of Man" comes vividly to mind. In the final scene of the film "Knowledge or Certainty," Bronowski wades out into a muddy stream at the Auschwitz prison camp. Kneeling down, he scoops up a handful of mud from the very pond into which were flushed the ashes of some four million people. Reflecting upon what men do to one another when they are absolutely and dogmatically certain that they are right and have the final answer, Bronowski pleads with the film audience in the words of Oliver Cromwell: "'I beseech you, in the bowels of Christ, think it possible you may be mistaken.'"[13] The point is, creative doubt is a constructive expression of the recognition that one is not God and, therefore, just may be mistaken.

Keeping fundamental beliefs alive

A second argument stresses that creative doubt can play a role in keeping one's fundamental beliefs from becoming dead dogmas.

Most basic beliefs and value commitments are initially inherited from parents, peers, and society at large. If these beliefs and commitments are not challenged by creative doubt, they tend to become simply verbal professions having little vitality. Creative doubt stimulates the evaluation of beliefs. Beliefs found wanting may appropriately be discarded. Those found adequate may be reasserted with new vigor and life.

A case in point occurred at Emory University during the 1960s when T. J.

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Altizer was making national headlines with his death of God theology. His point of view certainly challenged traditional Christian belief. After a debate between Altizer and one of the more orthodox members of the religion faculty, a long-time Emory resident was overheard to observe that there had been more god-talk around Emory since Altizer had come on the scene than in the entire previous history of that Methodist university. Exaggerated though this claim may have been, it underlined the fact that Altizer, in challenging traditional dogma, was stimulating people to think seriously about their fundamental beliefs and commitments.

Fundamental beliefs need to be continually challenged if they are to remain alive and vigorous. Creative doubt accomplishes this. Indeed, without creative doubt how do a person's beliefs mature? Without creative doubt how does a person make his own that which he has simply inherited? It is often painful to evaluate critically one's inherited beliefs, but the pain gives birth to beliefs that are alive. Out of the pain come vital ideas that the person has made his own.

A college student encountered a professor who stimulated her to think in exciting ways about matters she had never seriously considered. Upon returning home, she began discussing with a member of her family some of the questions she was raising and some of the issues she was trying to think through. Some minutes into the conversation, she was interrupted: "If you just wouldn't think about these kinds of questions," she was admonished, "you would be so much happier." In one sense, perhaps. But also she would have been a little less human, and her fundamental beliefs would be considerably less alive.

Challenging the adequacy of symbols

In the third place, most, if not all, language about God is symbolic or analogical or mythological. Indeed, religious language is perhaps the language of myth and symbols *par excellence*. One is reminded again of Tillich's claim that "man's ultimate concern must be expressed symbolically, because symbolic language alone is able to express the ultimate."[14] His argument is that "the true ultimate transcends the realm of finite reality infinitely. Therefore, no finite reality can express it directly and properly."[15] At best, the finite can only point to the infinite, and symbols and myths are pointers pointing beyond themselves. Finite man labors to understand the infinite, and as he attempts to express his limited understanding, he produces a language that more or less adequately reflects the infinite.

If one grants that religious language never perfectly reflects the ultimate, is one not obliged to acknowledge this openly? Is one not obligated to doubt the full adequacy of the symbols and myths employed? And should not this doubt motivate one to work at developing language that more adequately reflects the nature of God?

Suggestive at this point is an observation made by John Stuart Mill. Honesty

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necessitates the recognition that if one had been born elsewhere, one would probably have adopted the religious tradition of that particular culture, whether that be Buddhism, Hinduism, Islam, or whatever.[16] Serious reflection on this fact should give rise to a kind of toleration that acknowledges that most religions seek to reflect ultimate value. Then the question becomes which religion (which set of symbols and myths) reflects ultimate value most adequately. Creative doubt encourages this question. Dogmatism and intolerance suppress this crucial inquiry.

Assume that one concludes that the symbols and myths of the Christian faith most adequately reflect ultimate value. Then the question becomes, which Christian symbols? Which myths? There is considerable diversity and disagreement even within Christendom itself. Even when one decides on a particular set of symbols, the task is not complete. For recall, no symbols are ever fully adequate to reflect the infinite. Creative doubt encourages the continual reappraisal of symbols so that they may, if possible, be replaced by more adequate reflections of the infinite.

For those who take religion seriously, at stake here is nothing less than idolatry: the one who never doubts the adequacy of his symbols is worshiping his symbols. To worship symbols is to worship the pointers to God rather than God; and to worship something other than God is, by definition, idolatry. Creative doubt, then, may serve as a check against idolatry itself.

Challenging the quest for certainty

Finally, consider a defense of creative doubt that involves challenging the value of the quest for certainty.

The quest for certainty (and the avoidance of doubt) often manifests itself in the effort to find some authority to whom burdensome freedom and responsibility can be surrendered. The easiest way to secure certainty is to surrender one's personal freedom and responsibility for making choices. Or, perhaps more accurately, the easiest way to secure the *illusion* of certainty is to surrender one's personal freedom and responsibility for making decisions. That this is so is the crucial point Fyodor Dostoevsky makes in "The Grand Inquisitor" passage of the *Brothers Karamazov*.[17]

Within the novel, "The Grand Inquisitor" is a story told by one brother, Ivan, to another, Alyosha. The story is set in Seville, Spain, during the period of the Inquisition. Specifically, the account relates a conversation that was to have transpired between the Grand Inquisitor, who had been in charge of burning the heretics, and Christ, who had returned momentarily to comfort the suffering.

As the confrontation develops, the Inquisitor accuses Christ of giving to man an unbearable burden—freedom. Nothing, argues the Inquisitor, has been more insupportable for human society than freedom. Did you forget that men prefer peace and even death to freedom of thought? Yet you have weighed man down with the fearful responsibility of having to choose freely the fundamental

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principles by which he lives. And man, who has wrestled fifteen centuries with the freedom he did not want, has finally found someone to whom he can hand over his burden; he has found an escape. Man has gratefully laid his freedom at our feet (the feet of the medieval Church). Because we, the Church, are willing to assume responsibility for the very freedom that man cannot stand, he bows before us as if we were gods. And so the Inquisitor concludes: "We have corrected Thy work and have founded it upon *miracle, mystery* and *authority*. And men rejoiced that they were again led like sheep, and that the terrible gift [freedom] that had brought them each suffering, was, at last, lifted from their hearts."[18]

Dostoevsky's insight is to the point. Freedom is a burden, for with freedom comes the responsibility of continually reevaluating the very foundations of one's life. This is a responsibility from which many try to escape. To flee from this burden, however, is to flee from the very freedom that is a defining characteristic of the fully human. One may quest for certainty and flee from freedom, doubt, and insecurity; but as Peter Bertocci put it, such flight "is to miss the whole point of being human."[19]

In summary, four arguments have been advanced in defense of creative doubt: 1) that such doubt is a means of constructively acknowledging human finitude, 2) that such doubt can play a crucial role in keeping one's fundamental beliefs alive and vital, 3) that, in the religious arena, such doubt is a valuable weapon against idolatry itself, and 4) that the avoidance of doubt may reflect a relinquishing of freedom and a dehumanizing quest for certainty.

A final but crucial note: Simply because there is an element of doubt and uncertainty surrounding fundamental principles should not prohibit commitment in depth to one's basic beliefs. The last thing to be encouraged is an intimidated individual, wholly indecisive and uncommitted. There is nothing incompatible between deep commitment to a principle and an open attitude (spawned by creative doubt) that makes possible a future reevaluation of that principle. There is nothing incompatible between commitment so significant that it results in action and creative doubt that challenges the individual to be open to the future and to change. It was Bertrand Russell who maintained that "to teach how to live without certainty, and yet without being paralyzed by hesitation, is perhaps the chief thing that philosophy, in our age, can still do for those who study it."[20]

Indeed, there is something majestic and compelling about the fact that in those areas of life where value is at stake, one must make an uncertain judgment and then act courageously. As someone has noted, the very essence of human dignity is the courage to be unsure.

Philip Blair Rice quotes Justice Oliver Wendell Holmes as once observing that, "'the highest courage is to stake everything on a premise that you know tomorrow may disprove.'"[21] Rice then adds an even deeper insight: "If there is a still higher courage, it stems from the realization that the premises are such that tomorrow can neither prove nor disprove them in a way that will fully still our uncertainties."[22]

Finally, as Paul Tillich puts it:

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Doubt is overcome . . . by courage. Courage does not deny that there is doubt, but it takes the doubt into itself as an expression of its own finitude. . . . Courage does not need the safety of an unquestionable conviction. It includes the risk without which no creative life is possible.[23]

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